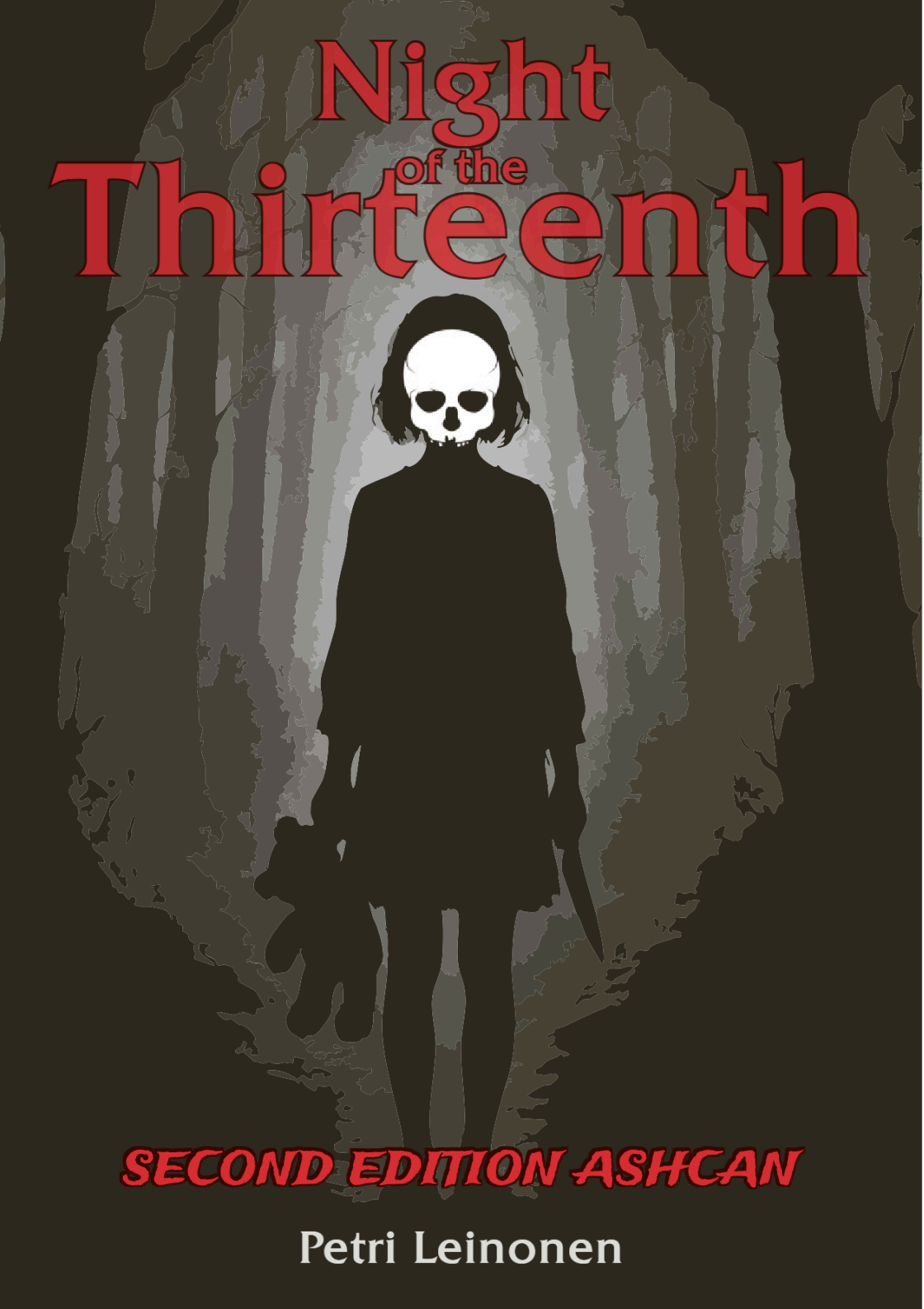
Night of the Thirteenth



SECOND EDITION ASHCAN

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Revised Interaction Core by The Table

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Uses the
Vectorized Playing Cards 3.2
https://totalnonsense.com/open-source-vector-playing-cards/
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Optional playset rules

Some playsets change how the deck is built or how fast the body count rises.

Classic Setup

Instead of random number piles, you can build the deck the classic way. Shuffle the **2s, 3s, 4s**, and one **Jack** together to form the **Threat Deck**, with the four **Aces** face up on top. Shuffle the **5s through 10s** separately and stack them in order from 5s on top to 10s on the bottom as the **Number Reserve**. Take the bottom card (a random 10) and place it face up to start the **Trophy Pile**.

Final Girl Rule

For a deadlier slasher (like *Summer Camp Massacre*), merely drawing a **Face Card** onto the table immediately inflicts one **Strike**. In addition, the final act and **The Endgame** begin the moment only **one surviving character** is left alive.

This is an Ashcan - it assumes you know something about TTRPGs and does not walk you through everything you need to do.

No Director, Only Victims - There is no permanent Game Master to guide you or save you. In each scene, one of you is the **Active Player** - the protagonist and the director for that scene, with the final say (and veto) over your character. Everyone else plays the world, the side characters, and the camera crew.

The Players - 4 players. You're there to play a character of a horror movie that is quite likely doomed.

You need a standard playing card deck with two distinct Jokers. And at least one pair of a d4 and a d10. 13 tokens to represent the Genre Points. Plus pen and paper for all of you to make notes.

Generally, more specific rules trump generic rules. And playset instructions supersede core rule instructions.

Setting up

1 - Choose the playset you're going to use

2 - Together, build the decks

3 - The players create their characters (now, or during the four Aces)

4 - You can begin. Good luck.

The d13

The game uses a "d13" die, which is a combination of a d10 and a d4. The d10, the **Main die**, is read so that the side that says 0 is actually a zero, so it produces results ranging from 0 to 9. The d4, or the **Effort die**, produces a result between 1 and 4. These are added together to get a result between 1 and 13.

A modifier can never raise or lower the result of a die above or below the ranges mentioned above.



The Table Setup

The Threat Deck: The horror starts small. Take the **Face Cards**, **Aces**, and **Jokers** aside. Shuffle **8 random number cards** (2–10) and one **Jack** together. The deck is placed face down on the table. The four **Aces** are placed on top of this stack.

Once the **Aces** are resolved, up to two cards from the **Threat Deck** are revealed face up on the table, showing the next challenges and the **Difficulty** that must be beaten to succeed against them.

The Reserves: The remaining cards are set aside in five piles: the **Number Reserve** (14 random number cards face down; remove any leftover number cards unseen), the **Face Card Reserves** (the remaining **Jacks**, **Queens**, and **Kings**, each in their own pile), and the two **Jokers**, kept separate for the final act.

If there are no cards left in a Reserve you would need to pull from, pull from the next closest Reserve pile instead.

The Trophy Pile: To begin the night with a sense of dread, take the top card from the **Number Reserve** and place it face up to start the **Trophy Pile** (leaving 13 cards in the Reserve). The **Trophy Pile** is stacked face up, so that the top card of it is always visible, and it sets the **Base Difficulty** for any **Test** against the **Killer**.

The Threat Cards on top determine the next challenge.



These get added to the Threat Deck as the game progresses

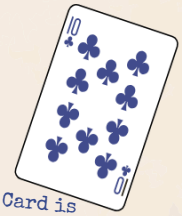




And these when you get to the Endgame



13 Genre Points for the table to hand out



If the Threat Card is a face card, this is what determines the Base Difficulty

The Threat Card

Up to two cards from the **Threat Deck** are visible on the table. The one you choose tells you what the next challenge and thus the next **Test** is going to be. This is the **Threat Card**.



How hard the next challenge is going to be.

What the challenge will be about

The Suit

... of the **Threat Card** tells you something about the nature of it.

- ♠ : Power - physical challenges
- ♥ : Resolve - challenges of nerves
- ♣ : Intellect - know-how challenges
- ♦ : Finesse - precise challenges

The Number

... of the **Threat Card** tells how severe the challenge is and the **difficulty** you need to roll against to solve it.

- **1 (Ace)** : establishing shot (prologue). Its difficulty is 1, so it always succeeds.
- **2–5** : low-intensity, potentially dangerous **Tasks**.
- **6–10** : high-intensity, dangerous **Tasks**.

Face cards

... represent a confrontation with the Killer. When a face card is on the table, no second card is drawn and you **must** choose the face card.

The suit of the **Threat Card** still sets the nature of the challenge.

The difficulty is determined by adding the **Trophy Pile's** top card to the modifier (below) from the face card in question.

Jack +1 / Queen +2 / King +3



Face card, so you're going to face the Killer for your next challenge!

Setting the Scene

Play moves around the table one scene at a time. In each scene, the **Active Player** steps into the spotlight as the protagonist and director for that scene, while the others act as the camera crew, the world, and the side characters.

The Prologue & Turn Order (Aces)

The game begins with the four **Aces** on top of the **Threat Deck**, one at a time. Each Ace is an establishing shot for the character with that **Aptitude**, who must be the **Active Player**. Its difficulty is 1, so it always succeeds. When finished, take your resolved Ace and keep it **face up** in front of you as your **turn-order token**.

After the prologue, only players with a **face-up Ace** can be chosen as the **Active Player**. When you finish your scene, flip your Ace **face down**. Once all living players have acted, flip all Aces **face up** again to start a new round.

Choosing a Threat Card

Start each scene with **one card** face up on the table (the unchosen card from the last scene, or draw one if the table is empty). Looking at only that one card, choose the **Active Player** for the scene - a half-blind decision. If the card is a number card, draw a **second card** face up so the Active Player has a choice. If the first card is a **Face Card** or **Joker**, do **not** draw a second card. Pick which card to face (if a **Face Card** is visible on the table, you **must** choose it).

Conversation and Stakes

The **Active Player** frames the scene using the card's suit and number (or the prompt in your playset or companion app). Other players **Focus the Camera** by asking sensory questions (*"What does it smell like?"*, *"How close is the Killer?"*). Once per scene, any other player can say **"Something's not right..."** and add one terrible detail that makes the situation worse; the Active Player must accept it.

Before rolling, the table asks: *"If you push yourself, what are you willing to sacrifice?"* Agree on a specific loss that happens on **Overexertion (3)** or worse, then roll the **d13**.

The Test

To overcome a challenge inspired by the **Threat Card**, you must make a **Test**.

To make the **Test**, roll a **d13**. Compare your roll to the **Threat Card's** difficulty. If your roll is equal to or greater than the difficulty, you **Succeed**. If it's less, it is a **Failure**.

Whether you succeed or fail, the roll of your **Effort die** (the d4) tells you who narrates the outcome and what it costs you.



Effort

Success can have a price, failure more so. The number you rolled on your **Effort die** (the d4) is the **Effort** from the Test. It determines how you succeed or fail, and be warned: a higher roll is worse.

The Effort Scale

1 (Controlled): A moment of clean execution. You keep your cool and narrate how the Test goes, whether you succeed or fail, on your own terms.

2 (Pushing It): You do it, but it's messy. You narrate the outcome, and the others suggest two or three small costs (noise, scratches, lost time). You pick one to include.

3 (Overexertion): It comes at a personal cost. Whether you succeed or fail, the sacrifice you agreed on before rolling happens.

4 (Breaking Point): You barely pull it off (or suffer badly for trying), and the consequence is immediate. The agreed sacrifice happens, and the others suggest a **Twist** to make things worse. You choose which Twist comes true, and you gain one **Strike**.

Successes and Failures

After you've resolved a **Test**, the success or failure changes the state of the game.

Aces and Number cards

When you finish one of the four **Aces** in the prologue, remove the Ace from the game and keep it **face up** in front of you as your **turn-order token** (no card is drawn from the **Number Reserve**).

On a **Success** against a number card, the **Threat Card** is removed from the **Threat Deck** and placed on top of the **Trophy Pile**, setting a new **Base Difficulty** for when the Killer comes calling. Then add the next card from the **Number Reserve** to the bottom of the **Threat Deck**.

On a **Failure**, you stumble. The **Threat Card** is placed on the bottom of the **Threat Deck** to haunt you again later, and the next card from the **Number Reserve** is added to the bottom of the deck to accompany it. Whether you succeed or fail on any card, rolling a **Breaking Point (4)** on the **Effort die** always earns one **Strike**.

Face cards (Facing the Killer)

Success against the Killer is always costly. Based on your **Effort** (the d4), another face card from the **Face Card Reserves** is added to the **Threat Deck**. Either a random **Jack** for a controlled/messy (1 or 2 on the d4) success, or a random **Queen** for an overexerted/dire (3 or 4 on the d4) one.

If this was the **first time** a face card of its suit (♠, ♥, ♣, ♦) was defeated (you've succeeded in a test against it), you've found a **weakness of the Killer**. The **Threat Card** is removed from the game. Doing this for **all four suits** triggers the **Endgame**.

If you had already defeated a card of that suit, the **Threat Card** is not removed, but remains in the **Threat Deck**.

Failure is disastrous: you gain one **Strike**, and a random **King** is added from the **Face Card Reserves** to the bottom of the **Threat Deck**.

After resolving any confrontation with the Killer, the entire **Threat Deck** (including any other card on the table) and the **Trophy Pile** are shuffled, and new cards get revealed.

The Three Acts

Like any good slasher movie, the night is divided into three acts. As the decks change, the pace quickens from eerie quiet to a desperate fight to see the morning.

Act 1: The Setup

The Killer is out there, watching from the shadows, but hasn't struck in the open yet. You get to know the cast through the four **Aces** and the first few challenges from the deck.

Only the single **Jack** shuffled into the starting deck is lurking in Act 1. The moment that first **Face Card** is faced and resolved, whether you succeed or fail, **Act 2** begins.

Act 2: The Horror Story

Now you've seen the Killer face to face, and the hunt is on. More **Face Cards** enter the deck after every confrontation, and the **Number Reserve** steadily ticks down after every number card.

Your goal is to stay alive and defeat a **Face Card** of each suit (♠, ♥, ♣, ♦) to uncover all four of the Killer's **weaknesses**.

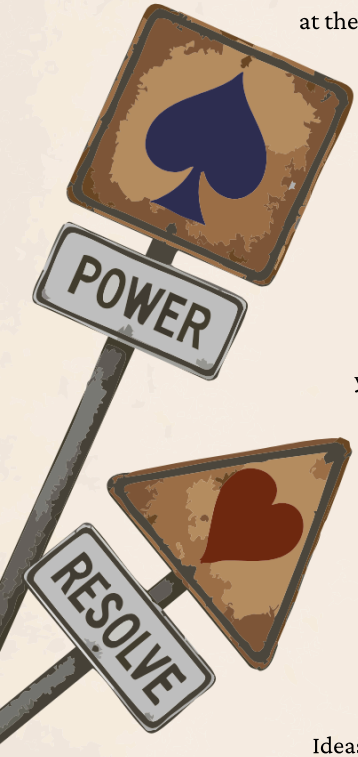
Act 3: The Climax

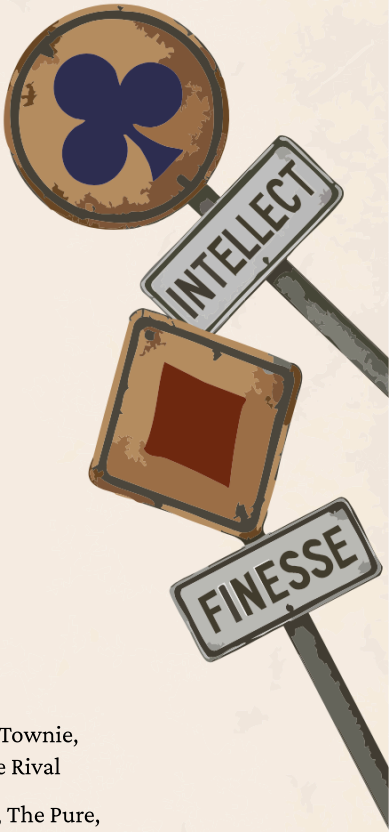
When you either find all **four weaknesses** or add the **last (13th) card from the Number Reserve** to the deck, time runs out and **Act 3** begins.

Remove **all number cards** from the **Threat Deck** (and set aside any left in the Reserve). There are no quiet scenes left. Only **Face Cards** remain, and every single test is a confrontation with the Killer until you uncover the last weakness and trigger **The Endgame**.

Creating the Cast

You are no heroes. You are just in the wrong place at the wrong time.





Choose a **Name**.

Come up with a clear **Archetype**.

Think of a reason **"Why are you here?"**.

Select an **Aptitude** (Power, Resolve, Intellect or Finesse). When doing a **Test** matching your Aptitude's suit, you can add or subtract one from your **Effort** die.

Archetype examples

Ideas for ♠ : The Jock, The Protective, The Townie, The Greaser, The Sheriff, The Father, The Rival

Ideas for ♥ : The Final Them, The Babysitter, The Pure, The Sibling, The Atoner, The New Kid, The Sheriff's Child

Ideas for ♣ : The Genre Savant, The Reporter, The Skeptic, The Loner, The Bookworm, The Techie, The Conspiracy Nut

Ideas for ♦ : The Rebel, The Class Clown, The Royal Bee, The Thief, The Rich Kid, The Cheerleader, The Slacker

For your consideration: It might make a more thematically balanced game if each player plays a character with a different **Aptitude**. This creates some tension from the get-go.

Using your character to influence rolls

Genre Points

Lean on the tropes

The table starts with 13 **Genre Points** that anyone can award you after a scene for playing into the genre's tropes. You can spend one **Genre Point** to **reroll your entire d13** and **add a +1** to that roll's **Main die**. You must accept the second result, and the spent point is removed from the game.

Aptitude

Do what you're good at

If in a **Test**, the suit of your character's **Aptitude** and the suit on the **Threat Card** are a match, you can add or subtract one from the **Effort die** result after the roll. This will affect both whether the **Test** was successful, and the severity of the **Effort**. When a character dies, their **Aptitude** is lost with them.



Three Strikes and you're out!

Everyone in Night of the Thirteenth gets two close calls with death before the end comes for them.

You get a Strike when you:

Fail any Test against the Killer.

Roll a Breaking Point (4) Effort in any Test.

A **Strike** means something horrible either happens to the character or *almost* happens to them. These triggers stack: failing against the Killer with a Breaking Point (4) roll inflicts **two Strikes** at once.

When you get your third **Strike**, the character's story is over. In a genre-fitting, gruesome fashion, of course. Come up with the most horrifying way to go with the rest of the table. Once they are dead, their Ace token and **Aptitude** are gone for the rest of the game.

The Endgame

Should you survive long enough to defeat a **face card** from all **four suits**, the night reaches its bloody climax. Remove **all number cards** from the **Threat Deck**, leaving only the monstrous **face cards**. Both **Jokers** are shuffled into this deck of horrors.

When a **Joker** is drawn from the top of the deck, its effect is triggered immediately. For any **Joker-activated Test** made during the **Endgame**, first shuffle the **Trophy Pile**, and the value of its top card becomes the **Difficulty** (no **Aptitude** can be used).



The Black Joker (The Twist): It feels like the end. You make one last, desperate attempt to fight back. Shuffle the **Trophy Pile** and reveal its top card to set the **Difficulty**. **Success** removes the highest face card from the deck; **failure** adds another **King**. The Black Joker is then removed from the game, both decks are shuffled, and the hunt continues.

The Red Joker (The End): This is it. The true finale. One character must make a final Test. Shuffle the **Trophy Pile** and reveal its top card to set the **Difficulty**.

Success: You've done it. You see the dawn. Any surviving characters have won.

Failure: The character making the Test is killed. The Red Joker is shuffled back into the deck, and the nightmare continues for any remaining survivors.



Quick Reference

Scene Flow

1. Scene Setup	Play the 4 **Aces** first (difficulty 1; keep your Ace face up as your turn token). Then: **1 card** visible → pick **Active Player** (face-up Ace) → draw 2nd card (unless Face Card/Joker) → pick 1 to face (**must** pick a Face Card). Flip your Ace face down after the scene.
2. The Stakes	Frame the scene, answer a sensory question, let anyone say *"Something's not right..."*, and agree on the **Overexertion** sacrifice.
3. The Test	Roll **d13** (**d10** 0–9 + **d4** 1–4). Spend a **Genre Point** to reroll +1, or use your matching **Aptitude** (±1 to the d4). Roll ≥ difficulty to **Succeed**.
4. Fallout	Narrate the outcome using your **Effort** roll, hand out Genre Points, mark any **Strikes** (Face Card failure and d4=4 stack!), and update the decks.

Difficulty

Ace	**1** (Prologue)
Number (2–10)	Card's number
J / Q / K	Trophy top **+1 / +2 / +3**
Joker	Trophy top **+0**

Effort (d4)

1 (Controlled)	Clean; you narrate it.
2 (Pushing It)	Pick 1 small cost.
3 (Overexertion)	Agreed sacrifice happens.
4 (Breaking Pt.)	Sacrifice + Twist + **1 Strike**.

Updating the Decks

Card	Success	Failure
Number	Move to top of **Trophy Pile**. Add 1 from Number Reserve to bottom of Threat Deck.	Move to bottom of **Threat Deck**. Add 1 from Number Reserve to bottom of Threat Deck.
Face Card	1st of its suit = **Weakness** (remove it). Add **Jack** (d4 1–2) or **Queen** (d4 3–4). Shuffle both decks.	Gain **1 Strike**. Add a **King** to the Threat Deck. Shuffle both decks.
Black Joker	Remove Black Joker and highest Face Card in deck. Shuffle both decks.	Remove Black Joker and add a **King**. Shuffle both decks.
Red Joker	**You see the dawn!** Survivors win.	**Character killed.** Shuffle Red Joker back in.

The Three Acts: **Act 2** starts after the first Face Card is resolved. **Act 3** starts when all 4 weaknesses are found or all 13 Number Reserve cards are added (remove all number cards from the deck). **The Endgame** shuffles in both Jokers once all 4 weaknesses are found.